



DOMINION
PARISH, BREMEN

Germany Opportunity Card

Skilled worker & Point-Based Pathways

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Background

Germany continues to face a significant shortage of skilled workers

This shortage affects nearly all occupational groups and represents a growing obstacle to economic growth.

Germany still faces major skilled-labour shortages: 163 of 1,200 assessed occupations were shortage occupations in 2024, keeping immigration reform high on the policy agenda.

List of shortage occupations according to Section 18g (1) (2) (1) of the Residence Act (AufenthG):



German Skilled Immigration Act reforms are in three stages

Implementation timeline, 2023–2024



Germany: Skilled labour shortages remain visible over time



Source: IAB Labour Shortage Index, Institute for Employment Research (IAB). Data: Jun 2018–Apr 2026; published 28 Apr 2026. Values rounded to one decimal.

EU Blue Card & recognized skilled workers: easier entry and employment rules

Experienced workers & trainees: broader access for people with professional experience or training pathways

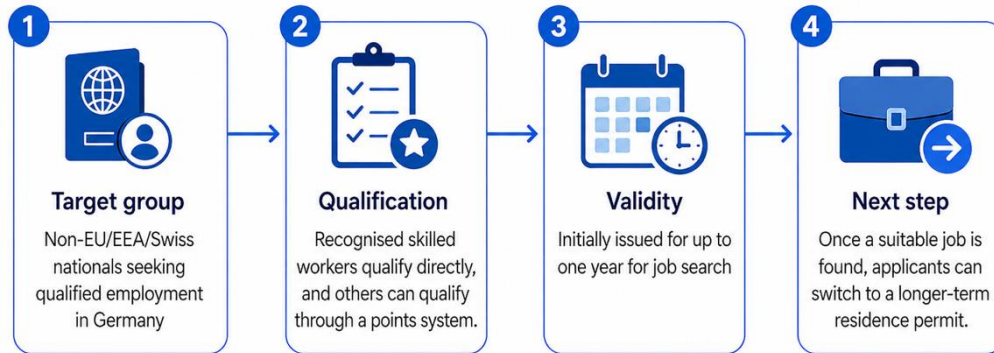
Opportunity Card: A new route allowing qualified non-EU jobseekers to enter Germany without a job offer and search for work for up to one year.

Disclaimer: This is not legal advice. Applicants should verify current rules before applying. Because requirements can change, rely on official German sources and the local checklist for your country of residence.

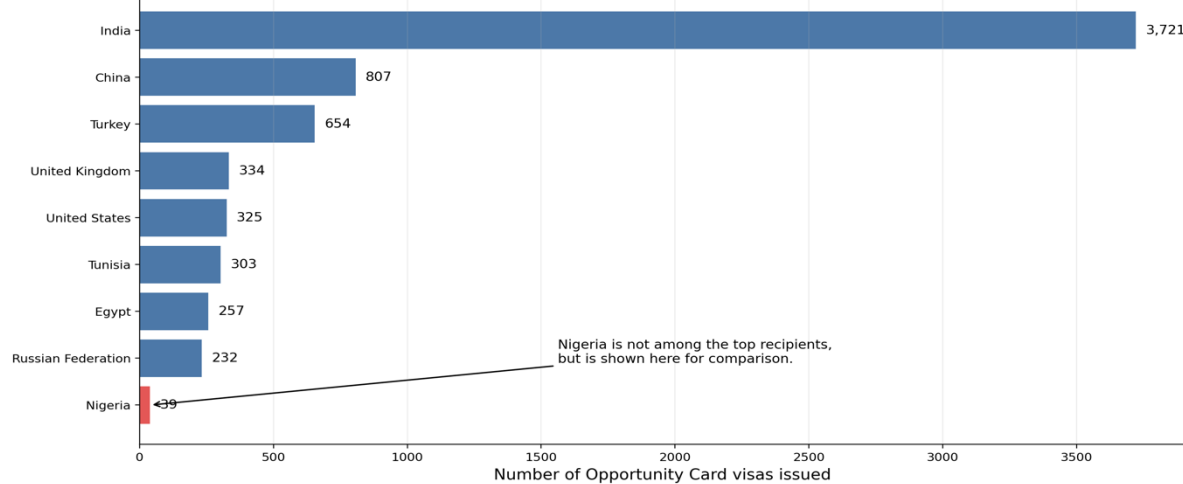
Opportunity Card (Chancenkarte)

Point-based Route for Qualified Jobseekers

To attract skilled workers by making job-search migration easier



11,497 Opportunity Card visas were issued by mid-June 2025

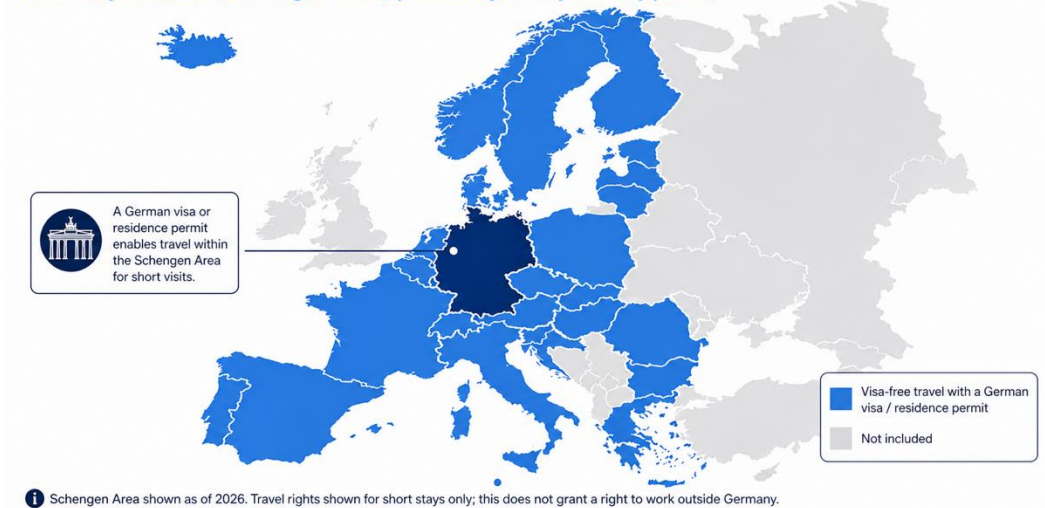


Sources: Country counts from a published list citing the German Federal Ministry of the Interior (visas issued by German diplomatic missions, 1 Jun 2024–15 Jun 2025). Total Opportunity Cards issued by 15 Jun 2025: 11,497.

Benefits:

- Enter Germany without a prior job offer and search for qualified employment locally
- Work part-time while job hunting, helping applicants gain income, experience, and employer contacts
- Transition into long-term residence once a suitable qualified job is secured.
- **Strategic positioning for suitable opportunities elsewhere**

Short stays across the Schengen Area (up to 90 days in any 180-day period)



Unlike the **regular Job Seeking Visa**, the **Opportunity Card** offers a points-based route with more flexible entry criteria and allows holders to work part-time while searching for qualified employment in Germany.

Eligibility pathways

**Do you have a qualification
recognized in Germany?**

YES: Skilled worker route

If the foreign academic/vocational qualification is fully recognised as equivalent to a German qualification, the points system is not required. Financial proof still applies.

NO / NOT FULLY: Points route

Applicants generally need a recognised-in-country qualification, language proof and at least six points under the selection criteria.

Pathway 1: Recognized skilled worker

How to prove certificate recognition:

Do you have a qualification
recognized in Germany?

YES: Skilled worker route

If the foreign academic/vocational qualification is fully recognised as equivalent to a German qualification, the points system is not required. Financial proof still applies.

1. Foreign degree holders should check Anabin database
<https://anabin.kmk.org/db/institutionen>

2. ZAB statement of comparability
<https://zab.kmk.org/en>

Cost: €208

Processing time: ~ 3-months

Pathway 2: Point-based route

Basic requirements:

1. Eligible qualification

Academic degree or vocational qualification. For vocational qualifications, training should generally be at least two years and state-recognised in the country of acquisition.

2. Language minimum

At least German A1 or English B2. Higher language levels can add points, but the minimum language proof is a separate gate.

3. Secure livelihood

Proof of financial means for the search period. Official 2026 guidance lists EUR 1,091 net per month, or a declaration of commitment.

Minimum points: 6+

Criterion	Points
Partial recognition	4
Shortage occupation	1
Professional experience	2-3
German language skills	1-3
English C1+ or native speaker	1
Age	1-2
Previous legal stay in Germany	1
Spouse/life partner also eligible	1

Pathway 2: Point-based route

Points breakdown:



Partial Recognition of Certificate

Awarded when German recognition authorities assess the foreign qualification as partially equivalent.



Shortage Occupation

Awarded when the applicant's formal qualification belongs to a listed shortage occupation.



Professional Experience

2 points: At least 2 years of relevant professional experience within the last 5 years.

3 points: At least 5 years of relevant professional experience within the last 7 years.

Pathway 2: Point-based route

Points breakdown:

Language proficiency

Level	Points
German A1	Baseline only; 0 points
German A2	1
German B1	2
German B2 or higher	3
English C1+ or native English speaker	1 additional point

Age

Under 35 at application: **2 points**
Age 35 to 39: **1 point**
Age 40 or older: **0 points**

Previous stay in Germany

1 point for a legal, continuous stay in Germany of at least 6 months within the last 5 years.

Spouse

1 point if the spouse also meets Opportunity Card requirements and you apply together.

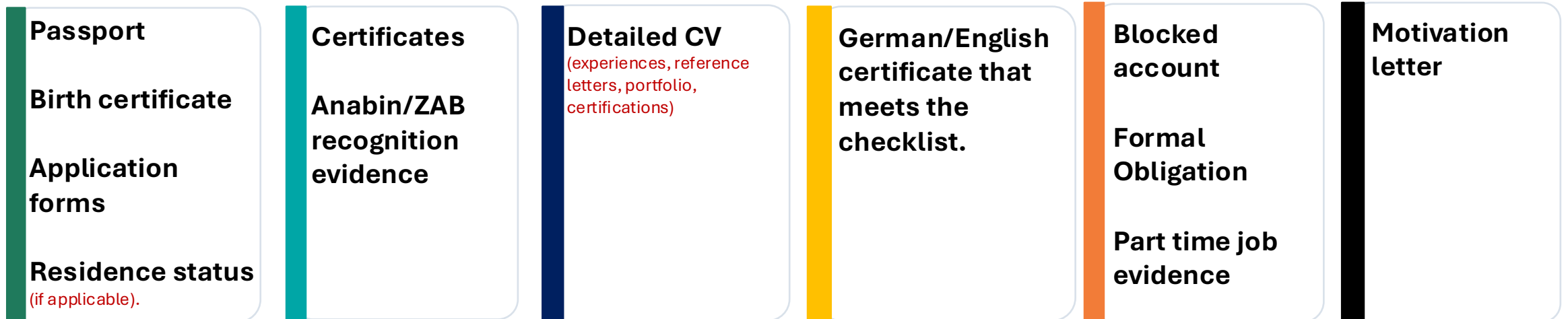
Pathway 2: Point-based route

Example scoring profile:

Profile	Score logic	Total
Young professional	Under 35 = 2 German B1 = 2 2+ years experience = 2	6
Experienced specialist	5+ years experience = 3 Under 35 = 2 Shortage occupation = 1	6
Partial recognition case	Partial recognition = 4 German A2 = 1 Previous legal stay = 1	6
Strong language route	German B2+ = 3 2+ years experience = 2 English C1+ = 1	6

Important: all examples still require baseline qualification, language, and livelihood evidence.

Application Documents



Application Documents

Motivation letter

A strong motivation letter must answer five questions:

Why Germany?

Labour-market fit, sector demand, career rationale— not just “better life.”

Why this occupation?

Show qualification, work experience and target roles connect logically.

Why now?

Explain readiness: language, funds, documents, applications, portfolio.

Where and how will you search?

Target cities, industries, platforms, employers, networking plan.

What is your fallback?

Credible plan if job search takes longer or fails.

Application Documents

Nigerian applicants

Document	Examples to prepare
Identity	Signed declaration, visa fee, biometric photo, passport, birth certificate; residence permit if non-Nigerian resident in Nigeria.
Education	Primary/secondary school records where required; WAEC/NECO; university/HND/vocational certificates; transcripts.
Qualification proof	Anabin printouts, ZAB Statement of Comparability where needed, partial/full recognition documents.
Motivation/job search	Signed motivation letter; evidence of recent job or training search in Germany.
Finance/insurance	Blocked account or other accepted proof; health insurance according to the checklist.



A few things to keep in mind

It gives you

Entry/stay in Germany to search for qualified employment or a recognition pathway.

Up to 12 months initially, depending on financial proof.

Permission for secondary work up to 20 hours/week while job searching.

Trial work for a maximum of two weeks per employer when linked to the job-search goal.

A local platform to meet employers, attend interviews and build networks.

It does not guarantee

A job offer or automatic employment in Germany.

Unlimited work rights during the search period.

Automatic permanent residence or citizenship.

Automatic family reunification without separate requirements.

Approval without documents proving funds, qualification, language and claimed points.

Common point-scoring mistakes

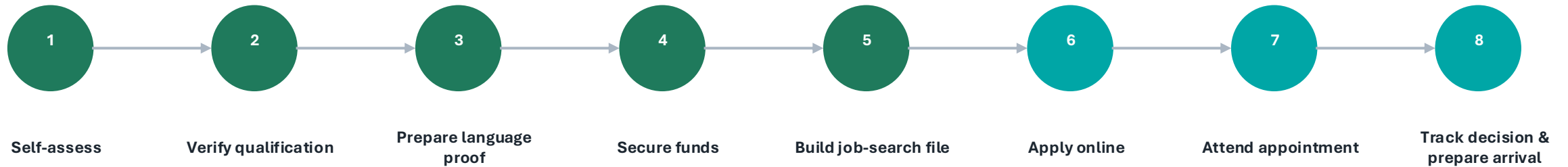
The 6-point threshold is only valid when the baseline requirements and evidence are also complete.

Mistake	Correction
Counting German A1 as a point	German A1 is a baseline language gate only. Points start at German A2.
Assuming English B2 gives a point	English B2 can satisfy the minimum language gate, but the extra English point is for C1+ or native English speaker.
Using any work experience to claim points	Experience should be relevant to the qualification and gained after completion of the qualification.
Counting tourist visits as previous Germany stay	The previous-stay point requires a legal, continuous stay of at least 6 months within the last 5 years; tourist/visitor stays do not count.
Thinking 6 points guarantees approval	Six points is only one layer. Applicants still need proof of qualification, language, funds, insurance, and country-specific checklist documents.

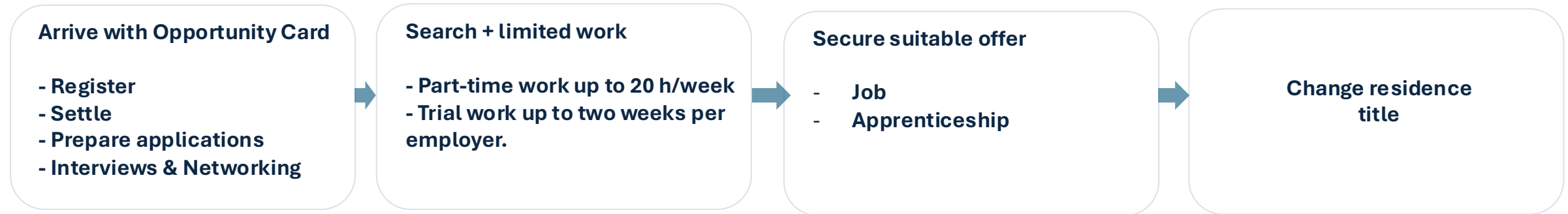


From application to arrival

Applicants from Nigeria



What happens after arrival?





Thanks
for
listening!

